

STAGE NINE • ENGLISH VOCABULARY FIRST SET

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage Nine • English Vocabulary First Set

PURPOSE

Stage Nine's six openers double as genuine warm-up drills, not just energizers — each one physically rehearses the core skill its session will teach, before a single vocabulary list is formally introduced. That's a deliberate choice given this stage's nature: vocabulary retention benefits enormously from a body and voice already warmed up, the same way a language class opens with a quick spoken activity rather than jumping straight into a word list.

Every icebreaker below is fast (8 minutes or under), physical or verbal rather than written, and connects directly to that session's actual content — an adjective memory game before adjective study, an interruption drill before meeting vocabulary, an improv “yes, and” warm-up before brainstorming vocabulary.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

Six Openers, One Per Session

SESSION 1

The Adjective Chain

TIME: 8 min

1. Standing or seated in a circle, the first person says one professional adjective (from any source, not just M1's list) describing themselves.
2. The next person repeats every adjective said so far, in order, then adds their own.
3. Continue until the chain breaks or everyone has gone once. No penalty for breaking it — just restart from that person.

WHY THIS WORKS

This is a genuinely fun memory game that also front-loads exactly the skill M1 needs: generating and holding onto precise, varied professional adjectives rather than defaulting to “hardworking” on repeat.

SESSION 2

Spot the Jargon

TIME: 8 min

1. Facilitator reads two short sample paragraphs aloud: one stiff and overloaded with formal phrases, one clear and naturally structured.
2. Group votes: which one would you actually want to receive in a real work email?
3. Quick discussion: what specifically made the “winning” one better — not just shorter, but exactly which language choices worked?

WHY THIS WORKS

Sets up the entire session's central tension — between M11 and M4's structural phrases, more isn't always better — before any individual list is taught.

SESSION 3

Fill the Silence

TIME: 8 min

1. In pairs, Partner A talks continuously about any harmless topic (weekend plans, a favorite show) for 30 seconds without stopping.
2. Partner B's only job is to jump in with a natural entry phrase (“if I could just add,” “building on that”) and take over, without ever saying “sorry to interrupt.”
3. Swap roles. Debrief: did the interruption feel natural or awkward?

WHY THIS WORKS

This is the exact live skill M16 is built around — entering a conversation naturally — practiced

physically before any vocabulary is formally introduced.

SESSION 4

The 10-Second Hook

TIME: 8 min

1. Each participant has exactly 10 seconds to “open” an imaginary presentation on a random, silly topic (facilitator provides: “why Tuesdays are underrated,” “the ideal sandwich”).
2. No prep time — this is meant to be quick and a little chaotic.
3. Group votes on the two or three openers that would genuinely make them want to hear more.

WHY THIS WORKS

Low-stakes and genuinely funny, this surfaces the real difference between a vague, hesitant opener and a confident hook — exactly what M26 addresses next, without the pressure of a real topic.

SESSION 5

Speed Greet

TIME: 8 min

1. Two lines face each other. Each pair has 20 seconds to greet each other appropriately for a randomly assigned context (facilitator calls out: “old colleague,” “new client,” “your boss's boss”).
2. One line rotates after each round, so everyone meets several partners across several contexts.
3. Debrief: which context felt hardest to calibrate correctly?

WHY THIS WORKS

This is a fast, physical warm-up for exactly the calibration skill M19 teaches — matching greeting formality to context — practiced under light time pressure before the formal list is introduced.

SESSION 6

Yes, And — But Make It Work Problems

TIME: 8 min

1. In small groups, one person names a small, real (or invented) workplace annoyance (“the printer is always broken”).
2. Each next person must respond with “yes, and” plus a genuine build on the idea — no shutting it down, no “that won't work.”
3. Run for 90 seconds, then switch to a new starting annoyance with a new person leading.

WHY THIS WORKS

This is a classic improv warm-up that does real, direct work for M36's brainstorming vocabulary — physically practicing the discipline of building rather than evaluating, before the vocabulary itself is introduced.